



Photographs by CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

IN PASADENA, Brenda Sharpe lives with her three younger children in Hotel Le Reve. It's the sixth place they've lived since the Eaton fire damaged their home in Altadena, where Sharpe once cleaned houses.

Looking for a place to land

By LIAM DILLON

Since her Altadena rental home burned down in January's Eaton fire, Tamara Johnson has crisscrossed Southern California looking for a place to live. She started in San Bernardino, where she stayed with a friend, and continued to Oceanside, where an Airbnb voucher let her remain a week. She's driven from Long Beach to Azusa searching for apartments, spending her days scanning listings for those that would accept her Federal Emergency Management Agency housing assistance and calling 211 for help. Most nights, she's slept in her van. The worst came when a truck smashed into the back of her vehicle one morning as she was pulling into a fast-food parking lot. Johnson got a rental car and then slept in that.

"I'm going through all this," said Johnson, 62. "And I just came through a disaster."

With her struggles, Johnson was surprised to learn that there could have been another path to long-term housing. After major wildfires, floods, hurricanes,

[See **FEMA**, A9]

FEMA often directly leases apartments for disaster survivors. Why didn't that happen after the L.A. County wildfires?



SHARPE'S parents' house was destroyed in the blaze, and her grandmother, who had to be carried to safety by firefighters, has since passed away.

TIMES INVESTIGATION

LAFD union leader racked up overtime pay

By ALENE TCHEKMEYDIAN AND PAUL PRINGLE

Long before the devastating fire in Pacific Palisades, leaders of the Los Angeles Fire Department's labor union complained that the agency did not have enough money to keep the city safe.

"It's a damn shame, and excuse my language, that it

took this incident, the Pacific Palisades, to finally bring attention to our grossly understaffed, underfunded Fire Department," Freddy Escobar, president of the United Firefighters of Los Angeles City, said at a city Fire Commission meeting in February.

Union leaders, along with top LAFD commanders, said budget cuts had resulted in a backlog of engines needing repairs and

not enough mechanics to fix them. But even as they denounced those reductions, the union leaders secured four years of pay raises for the city's 3,300 firefighters through negotiations with Mayor Karen Bass. And firefighters often make much more than their base pay, with about 30% of the LAFD's payroll costs going to overtime.

That includes Escobar and other top union officers,

who have for years been padding their paychecks with overtime while also collecting a five- to six-figure union stipend, a Times investigation found.

Escobar made about \$540,000 in 2022, the most recent year for which records of both his city and union earnings are available. He more than doubled his base salary of \$184,034 with overtime payouts that year,

[See **LAFD**, A7]

Huge quake could sink swath of state, study says

Some areas might drop more than 6 feet, increasing the risk of flooding



MARLI MILLER UCG/Universal Images Group

A MEGAQUAKE could drastically alter shorelines, the study says. Above, visitors at Cape Perpetua, Ore.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

A long-feared monster earthquake off California, Oregon and Washington could cause some coastal areas to sink by more than 6 feet, dramatically heightening the risk of flooding and radically reshaping the region with little to no warning.

Those are the findings of a new study that examined the repercussions of a massive earthquake on the Cascadia subduction zone, which stretches from Northern California up to Canada's Vancouver Island.

The study, published

Monday in the journal Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, concluded that in an earthquake scenario with the highest level of subsidence, or land sink, the area at risk of flooding would expand by 116 square miles, a swath that's 2½ times the size of San Francisco.

Such a scenario would more than double "the flooding exposure of residents, structures and roads," and officials would need to contend with a future of "compromised roadways and bridges," as well as lifelines and infrastructure that are either more frequent

[See **Earthquake**, A12]

State law aims for equity in student discipline. Trump says it's illegal

Executive order could challenge the ending of suspension rules that hurt Black and Latino students.

By DANIEL MILLER

Violating a school dress code. Using a cellphone in class. Mouthing off at a teacher.

There was a time when that kind of behavior, called "willfully defiant" conduct, would get a California public school student suspended.

But over the last decade, a sea change in state discipline policy — one born in part out of an understanding that such suspensions disproportionately affect Black, Latino and Indigenous students — largely outlawed that kind of punishment.

Instead, schools were advised to turn to practices including conflict resolution and counseling.

Now, though, an executive order signed by President Trump could presage legal challenges of pioneering California laws that overhauled school discipline by banning willful defiance suspensions for K-12 students.

In his April 23 order, Trump directed the Education Department to root out school discipline frame-

works based on "discriminatory equity ideology" and issue new "commonsense" practices in the nation's K-12 schools, while criticizing previous guidance from Democratic administrations. President Obama had directed schools to avoid enacting discipline policies that disproportionately punished underrepresented student groups — a stance later supported by President Biden.

Trump has said such rules amount to racial discrimination because, his order stated, the Obama-era directive "effectively required schools to discriminate on the basis of race by imposing discipline based on racial characteristics, rather than on objective behavior alone."

The executive order has sown confusion among educators and attorneys, who wonder about its potential impact on California — with some saying they see it as a corollary to the Trump administration's wide-scale attack on diversity, equity and inclusion programs.

"Shock and awe is the goal here — to shake people up and disrupt," said Pedro A. Noguera, dean of USC's Rossier School of Education. "But ... where's the guidance? Where's the desire to produce evidence that what they are doing will be helpful to children? None

[See **Discipline**, A6]

Justices may allow taxpayer-funded church-run schools

Case underscores shift in religion law under court's conservative majority and could change public schools.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court's conservative majority appeared poised Wednesday to rule that church-run schools have a right to operate as public-funded charters.

If so, the decision could transform K-12 education and public schooling nationwide.

Since the early 1990s, charter schools have taken hold in California and 46 other states as a popular public-funded option for parents and their children. They enroll 3.5 million children nationwide.

The Golden State is home to 1,300 charter schools serving nearly 630,000 students, about 11% of those attending kindergarten through 12th grade, according to the California School Boards Assn.

It has been understood those schools are both public and "nonsectarian," or not religious.

In authorizing charter schools, lawmakers and education officials believed the Constitution's ban on an "establishment of religion" and the principle of church-state separation prohibited using tax money to fund churches or teach religion.

But the court's conservatives said Wednesday that they believe it is unfair and unconstitutional to turn

down church-run schools as tax-funded charters.

"They are saying don't exclude us because of our religion," said Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh.

Washington attorney Gregory Garre said it would be "remarkable" for the court to overrule Congress and the laws of 47 states and to instead require them to fund church-sponsored

[See **Justices**, A6]

Where are mass deportations?

Deportees from U.S. have yet to materialize in Mexico, which takes migrants from third countries. **WORLD**, A3

Backlog is cited in sex abuse case

Allegations against a youth soccer coach in 2024 languished until a boy was killed this year. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Lakers coverage available online

For full coverage of Game 5 against the Timberwolves, go to the eNewspaper and **latimes.com/sports**.

Weather
Low clouds dissipate. L.A. Basin: 71/57. **B6**

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